MUSIC

Perfect Mix

A cappella group Penn Masala return to India with their pioneering blend of Indian and international sounds

When the US-based Penn Masala take the stage during their six-city tour of India in May **(tickets available on BookMyShow)**, audiences will see a fairly different set of members from those in their last act in 2017. That's because the composition of "the world's first Hindi-English fusion a cappella group", comprising students from the University of Pennsylvania, keeps changing with freshmen joining and graduates leaving each year.

"We've had people stay up till seven years," says president Saaketh Narayan, who is among the 13 singers and beatboxers that make up the current version of Penn Masala, a group formed in 1996 and whose alumni number almost 100. The group's list of achievements includes releasing 12 studio albums, performing at The White House for former US President Barack Obama's Diwali celebrations in 2009, and an appearance in the film *Pitch Perfect 2* in 2015.



THE COMPOSITION OF PENN MASALA **KEEPS CHANGING AS NEW STUDENTS JOIN** AND GRADUATES LEAVE EACH YEAR

Penn Masala, who pioneered the Bollywood-international pop mashups that are now routinely seen online, have consistently expanded their sound. Most recently, they started covering Tamil and Telugu songs. This is a result of there being "a lot of South Indians in the group right now [and] South Indian music in general becoming more popular", says incoming music director Prateek Adurty. He's taking over the reins from Albert Gu, who is Chinese and the only non-South Asian member.

While Penn Masala have incorporated various languages and members of different ethnicities, they don't plan, at least in the near future, to admit women. This is for a couple of reasons: all their music so far has been written for the male voice, and the UPenn campus is already home to Penn Atma, a South Asian a cappella act comprising female and non-binary members. Fans can, however, look forward to them working together soon. "They sound awesome, so expect collaborations," says Adurty.

They also aim to collaborate with Indian musicians during their tour, which is produced by BookMyShow's TribeVibe division. Attendees will hear songs from their last album *Midnight Oil* (2022), some originals, and "Masala classics that we always have in our setlist". The evergreens include mashups of Coldplay's 'Viva La Vida' with A.R. Rahman's 'Jashn-e-Bahara' from *Jodhaa Akbar* (2008), and Jay Sean's 'Down' with Vishal-Shekhar's 'Desi Girl' from *Dostana* (2008).

The gigs, which will be held in New Delhi, Mumbai, Pune, Hyderabad, Bengaluru and Goa, will be a mix of melancholy tunes, high-energy tracks and a few skits, says Adurty. "We try to make it an experience rather than just an a cappella show." ■

Amit Gurbaxani

WATCHLIST

OTHER ACTS TO CATCH IN MAY



BACKSTREET BOYS

The 1990s American boy band, which last performed in India in 2010, will play concerts in Mumbai and New Delhi as part of their DNA World Tour. The zones at the venues have been named after hits such as 'Everybody', 'I Want It That Way' and 'All I Have To Give'.



THE SOUND OF MUSIC

This production of the Rodgers and Hammerstein musical, helmed by Tony Award winner Jack O'Brien, will be staged at Mumbai's Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre. It stars Jill-Christine Wiley as Maria and Trevor Martin as Captain von Trapp.

REMA

The debut India tour of Nigerian Afrobeats star Rema will cover Mumbai, Pune, New Delhi, Bengaluru and Hyderabad. The singer shot to fame with his single 'Calm Down', which has topped the charts globally.

